Earlier, different unit systems were used by people from different countries. Some of the unit systems followed earlier are given below in Table 1.1.

Table 1.1 Unit systems of earlier times

System	Length	Mass	Time
CGS	centimetre	gram	second
FPS	foot*	pound	second
MKS	metre	kilogram	second

* foot is the singular of feet

At the end of the Second World War there was a necessity to use worldwide system of measurement. Hence, SI (International System of Units) system of units was developed and recommended by General Conference on Weights and Measures at Paris in 1960 for international usage.

1.2 SI System of Units

SI system of units is the modernised and improved form of the previous system of units. It is accepted in almost all the countries. It is based on a certain set of fundamental units from which derived units are obtained by proper combination. There are seven fundamental units in the SI system of units. They are also known as base units and they are given in Table 1.2.

The units used to measure the fundamental quantities are called fundamental units and the units which are used to measure the derived quantities are called derived units.

Table 1.2 Fundamental quantities and their units

Fundamental quantities	Unit	Symbol
Length	metre	m
Mass	kilogram	kg
Time	second	s
Temperature	kelvin	K
Electric current	ampere	A
Luminous intensity	candela	cd
Amount of substance	mole	mol

With the help of these seven fundamental units, the units for other derived quantities are obtained and their units are given below in Table 1.3.

1.3 Fundamental Units

1.3.1 Length

Length is the extent of something between two points. The SI unit of length is metre. One metre is the distance travelled by light through vacuum in 1/29,97,92,458 second.

Table 1.3 Derived quantities and their units

S.No	Physical quantity	Expression	Unit
1	Area	length × breadth	m^2
2	Volume	area × height	m^3
3	Density	mass / volume	kgm^{-3}
4	Velocity	displacement / time	ms^{-1}
5	Momentum	mass × velocity	$kgms^{-1}$
6	Acceleration	velocity / time	ms^{-2}
7	Force	mass × acceleration	$kgms^{-2}$ or N
8	Pressure	force / area	Nm^{-2} or Pa
9	Energy (work)	force × distance	Nm or J
10	Surface tension	force / length	Nm^{-1}

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